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What sparked your passion for learning, and how has your career in L&D evolved since then?

L(earning), where 'L' stands for Life Long, resonates deeply with me. I believe that to be a good teacher, one must be a great learner and never lose the curiosity we had as children. Throughout my student life, I was always on stage and loved holding the mic — whether it was for elocution competitions or hosting events. I naturally transitioned to training soon after I started my career in Operations. I have taken on multiple roles within the HR spectrum, with L&D being one of them. As an L&D practitioner, my high point was setting up the first ever version of the Tata Communications Learning Academy and getting the Kirkpatrick Gold Certification. I have trained colleagues across the world on diverse topics, ranging from technology to the 7 Habits of Highly Effective People. Today, I am responsible for the Learning and Development at Tata Communications and I can confidently say I'm living my dream.

What strategies have you found most effective in fostering an Adaptive Learning Culture at Tata Communications, and how have they impacted organizational success?

At Tata Communications, we have strategically linked learning to individual growth and, ultimately, to measurable business impact. Our primary focus is fostering a culture of continuous learning, anchored in our core values and leadership's commitment to "Walk the Talk".

To achieve this, we have democratized access to learning through our award-winning LXP

platform, Tata Communications Learning Academy, powered by Degreed. By strategically integrating premium platforms like Techademy, we cater to diverse individual needs and aspirations. The platform's content is meticulously curated and regularly updated to align with the organization's evolving requirements. In addition, we offer bespoke skill-based and customized role-based programs, explicitly linking them to business outcomes. This approach is underpinned by the 70:20:10 model, ensuring a holistic learning experience:

➤ 10% formal learning, focusing on structured content.

➤ 20% outside-in perspectives, including peer learning, coaching, and expert insights.

➤ 70% practical application, emphasizing on-the-job learning and real-world implementation.

This integrated strategy has delivered consistent, year-over-year benchmarking results, positioning us as a true learning organization, committed to continuous improvement and impact.

With advancements in generative AI, how do you envision the L&D landscape evolving, particularly in relation to Future Skills?

'AI, for me, is basically Augmenting Intelligence and not artificial intelligence.' The industry is undergoing a massive shift with the shelf life of skills shrinking every day. What is niche today will be vanilla tomorrow. Fortunately, we embarked on this journey early, establishing unified, AI-enabled HR platforms. By leveraging AI and platform technology, we have seamlessly integrated workforce planning, hiring, and learning to ensure future readiness

in skills and roles, creating a unified experience that drives business outcomes.

1. For example: At Tata Communications, when you raise a job request, you instantly see relevant internal and external candidates and can nudge them to apply.

2. Every employee can log in to our career platform, explore career paths, identify skills gaps instantly, and begin a learning journey to bridge those gaps.

Balancing learning and performance can be challenging. How do you approach aligning learning initiatives with performance metrics?

Begin with the end in mind. I practice the Kirkpatrick framework, where we first define the desired results (performance metrics), then outline the behaviors that will drive those results. From there, we work backwards to design the learning program and assessments. The final phase focuses on the learner's experience, i.e. "Did the learner enjoy the process? Or did it push them outside their comfort zone to explore and learn new things?"

Looking at the broader L&D community, are there any innovative practices or trends that resonate with your vision of continuous learning and adaptive culture?

I feel that we should continue to focus on future skills, staying ahead of time, and ensuring an agile workforce is ready to embrace change and growth at scale. A strong 'What's in it for me?' is essential. Our talent strategy focuses on 'Build First, Buy When Necessary,' emphasizing internal talent development before external hiring. The organization-wide focus is on internal mobility as a cornerstone for building a future-ready workforce while fostering individual career growth.

Given the fast-paced nature of industry changes, what advice would you give to other L&D leaders on building an agile, future-focused approach to learning and development?

I've always believed that the best way to grow is through hands-on engagement with new challenges and opportunities. As an L&D leader, I invest time in exploring new ways of learning, content creation, automation, and AI use cases. My advice to L&D leaders would be to take risks and encourage experimentation by creating a culture where employees can try new approaches without fear of failure. This strategy fosters innovation and adaptability.